A tale of scales

Reptile skin is covered in overlapping, waterproof plates called scales. This layer of skin is good at keeping moisture inside, so that reptiles can survive in hot, dry places.

Snake

Caiman

Skink (a lizard)

Tortoise

Sensible outfits

Skinks and snakes have smooth, flexible scales for burrowing or moving across ground. The leathery scales of caimans are strengthened by bony plates on the back and belly – while tortoises have a tough, warty covering on their head and legs.

Reptile skin does three main jobs. It keeps water out, body moisture in, and protects the creature's inside parts from injury during fights or attacks.

Spines and crests

Many reptiles have rough, granulelike scales that rise into spiked points along their back. The sharp spines are good for defense – and often form beautiful crests, which are useful for attracting a mate.

Gecko (a lizard)